Aantarika
The Design Studio

FREE PLANNING GUIDE

Plan your home interiors *without the gamble*

A practical guide for Bengaluru homeowners. Budgets, timelines, materials, and the questions that save you lakhs before you sign anything.

Aantarika · The Design Studio
Luxury turnkey interiors · J.P. Nagar, Bengaluru · Since 2016

A HOMEOWNER'S
PLANNING HANDBOOK

START HERE

Most interiors do not fail on design. They fail on planning.

You have seen the mood boards and the before-and-after reels. What you rarely see is the part that decides whether your project is a joy or a headache: the planning you do before a single panel is cut.

Across hundreds of Bengaluru homes, the same four things go wrong, and almost always for the same reason. A little planning up front prevents each one.

₹ The quote balloons

A clean number at signing slowly grows once work starts and "extras" appear that were never written down.

45 days becomes 9 months

Without a locked design and a single accountable team, the timeline drifts and you live in a half-finished home.

The team goes quiet

The calls slow down right after the advance is paid, and you start chasing your own project for updates.

You manage five vendors

Carpenter, electrician, painter, modular supplier and a designer, all pointing at each other when something slips.

What is inside this guide

Six short chapters and a checklist you can use whatever your budget or project size.

01	**Set a budget that holds**	Where the money actually goes, and the three traps
02	**The realistic timeline**	The phases, and where projects really slip
03	**Materials that last**	Boards, finishes and hardware, in plain language
04	**Room by room**	The decisions people most often regret skipping
05	**Questions before you sign**	Ten that separate a safe firm from a risky one
06	**Red flags and a checklist**	What to walk away from, and a one-page list

01 Set a budget that holds

A budget only protects you if it is itemised. A single round number is a promise waiting to be broken.

Where the money actually goes

Interior spend is not one bucket. Seeing the split helps you decide where to invest and where to hold back. As a rough guide, a full home interior tends to break down like this.

AREA OF WORK	SHARE OF BUDGET	WHAT IT COVERS
Modular and woodwork	40 to 50%	Kitchen, wardrobes, storage, TV units, study and pooja
Ceiling, electrical, lighting	15 to 20%	False ceiling, wiring changes, light points and fixtures
Loose furniture and decor	12 to 18%	Sofas, beds, dining, curtains and soft furnishing
Painting	8 to 12%	Putty, primer, two coats, texture or accent walls
Flooring, if redoing	8 to 12%	Tiles, wooden flooring or stone, plus labour
Design and management	5 to 10%	Drawings, 3D, site supervision and coordination

Rough planning proportions only. Your split shifts with finishes, how much furniture is custom, and whether civil work is involved.

A starting range for Bengaluru

2 BHK, full interior	~ ₹6 to 12 lakh
3 BHK, full interior	~ ₹10 to 20 lakh
4 BHK or villa	₹18 lakh and up

Approximate, finishes change everything. Premium materials and bespoke furniture move the upper end well beyond these figures.

The three hidden traps

Scope creep. Small "while you are at it" additions that quietly add up. Fix the scope in writing.

Per square foot quotes. A rate with no bill of quantities hides as much as it reveals. Ask for line items.

Cheap hardware. Hinges and channels are where a low quote is recovered. It shows within a year.

> *Ask for an itemised estimate before you pay a rupee. A firm that will not put it on paper is telling you something.*

02 The realistic timeline

A full home interior is not slow. It only feels slow when nobody owns the schedule.

The seven phases, in order

1. **Design and finalisation.** Layouts, 3D views, materials and a locked scope. The most important phase, and the one worth not rushing.
2. **Estimate and sign off.** An itemised bill of quantities you approve before work begins. No surprises later.
3. **Material selection.** Boards, laminates, hardware, stone and tiles chosen and frozen, so production does not stall.
4. **Manufacturing.** Modular and woodwork built, ideally in a controlled facility rather than dusty on site.
5. **Site execution.** Civil, electrical, false ceiling and installation, sequenced so trades do not block each other.
6. **Finishing.** Painting, polishing, hardware fitting and the small details that decide how the home feels.
7. **Handover and support.** A walkthrough, a snag list closed, and a warranty you can actually call on later.

Where projects slip

Design changes after production starts. Materials picked late. Several vendors who do not share a schedule. Payments not tied to milestones, so there is no pressure to finish.

How to protect it

Lock the design before any cutting. Choose one team that is accountable end to end. Get the schedule in writing. Tie each payment to a stage that is actually complete.

> *One accountable team beats five separate vendors every single time. Coordination is the job, not an afterthought.*

03 Materials that last

Most interiors look good on day one. The materials decide how they look in year five.

Boards: the bones

The board behind the laminate matters more than the laminate. In kitchens, utility areas and anywhere near water, ask for boards rated for moisture.

- **BWP or marine grade** for kitchen and bathroom carcasses, where water is a fact of life.
- **BWR grade** for general wardrobes and storage in dry areas.
- Ask for the brand and grade in writing. "Good quality ply" is not a specification.

Finishes: the face

Each finish has a place. Match it to the room and how hard that surface will be used, rather than to a trend.

- **Laminate.** Hard-wearing and forgiving. The workhorse for most homes.
- **Acrylic.** High gloss, rich look, best away from heavy daily scuffing.
- **PU and veneer.** Warm and premium, worth it on feature pieces.

Hardware: where cheap quotes hide

You open and close a wardrobe thousands of times. Hinges, drawer channels and soft-close mechanisms are the first thing a low quote downgrades, and the first thing to fail. This is the one place to insist on a known brand.

✓ Insist on

- Branded hinges and channels, named in the estimate.
- Soft-close on doors and drawers you use daily.
- Moisture-rated board near water, no exceptions.
- Edge banding on every exposed edge, machine pressed.

× Safe to skip

- Glossy acrylic on low-use, low-visibility cabinets.
- Heavy false ceiling where a simple cove will do.
- Trend colours you may tire of, on permanent fixtures.
- Imported nameplates on parts no one ever sees.

04 Room by room

A quick reference of the decisions homeowners most often wish they had made differently.

Kitchen

- Plan the work triangle first: sink, hob, fridge within easy reach.
- Tall units and corner solutions add real storage people forget.
- Moisture-rated boards and a hard-wearing countertop are non-negotiable.
- Under-cabinet light is small money and changes daily life.

Wardrobes

- The internal layout matters more than the shutter finish.
- Map your clothes to shelves, hanging and drawers before sign off.
- Soft-close and full-extension drawers earn their cost.
- Plan one lockable drawer for documents and valuables.

Living room

- Light in layers: ambient, task and accent, not one bright tube.
- Decide the TV wall and cable routing before electrical work.
- Closed storage hides clutter better than open shelves.
- Leave walking space, do not over-furnish the room.

Bedrooms

- Bedside points for charging and reading save retrofits later.
- Storage under the bed is space most plans waste.
- A two-way switch at door and bed is a small daily win.
- Soft, warm light helps the room actually feel restful.

One habit that saves the most regret

Walk your daily routine through the plan before you approve it. Morning rush, cooking, laundry, where bags and shoes land. Storage and switches placed around real life beat a layout that only looks good in a render.

05 Questions before you sign

Ask these of any firm you consider. The answers separate a safe partner from an expensive lesson.

1. **Is the estimate itemised?** You want a line-item bill of quantities, not one lump figure.
2. **Do you make in-house or outsource?** In-house manufacturing usually means tighter quality and accountability.
3. **What exactly is in the price, and what is extra?** Get the exclusions in writing before, not after.
4. **How is payment scheduled?** Each instalment should be tied to a stage that is genuinely complete.
5. **Who handles changes, and at what cost?** A clear change process prevents the quiet budget creep.
6. **What boards and hardware brands do you use?** Named brands and grades, not "good quality".
7. **What is the timeline, in writing?** A schedule you can hold them to, with stage dates.
8. **What warranty do you give, and on what?** Length, what it covers, and how you actually claim it.
9. **Can I speak to recent clients?** Real homeowners, ideally with projects like yours.
10. **Who is my single point of contact?** One person accountable beats a group chat with no owner.

A simple test

A firm that answers all ten plainly, and puts the answers on paper, is a firm that has nothing to hide. Hesitation on warranty, exclusions or written timelines is the most useful signal you will get.

06 Red flags and your checklist

A few warning signs worth walking away from, and a one-page list to take into any conversation.

Walk away if you see

- A round-number quote with no itemised bill of quantities.
- A large advance demanded before any drawing exists.
- "We outsource that part" with no clear ownership.
- No written timeline, only verbal reassurance.
- No warranty, or one that is vague about what it covers.
- Pressure to pay today for a discount that vanishes tomorrow.

Before you start, tick these

- [x] Budget set, with a small buffer held back.
- [x] Scope written down and frozen.
- [x] Itemised estimate received and understood.
- [x] Design and 3D approved before any cutting.
- [x] Materials and hardware brands named on paper.
- [x] Payment tied to completed stages.
- [x] Timeline agreed in writing.
- [x] Warranty terms read, not just mentioned.
- [x] One accountable point of contact named.
- [x] Recent client references checked.

> *Get it in writing. Almost every interior horror story traces back to something everyone agreed to, but no one wrote down.*

ABOUT AANTARIKA

One team. One roof. Your home, without the gamble.

We are a Bengaluru interior studio that has handed over more than 800 homes since 2016. Design, materials, manufacturing, execution and after-care all sit under one roof and one accountable team, which is exactly how the four common headaches in this guide get prevented.

- Full home, turnkey, design to handover
- 100% in-house, not outsourced
- Itemised pricing, set in writing
- Up to a 10-year warranty on selected interior components

When the time is right

This guide is yours to use with any firm. When your project is a full home of ₹25 lakh or more here in Bengaluru, we would love to be one of the studios you talk to. No pressure, no obligation, just an honest design direction and a clear estimate.